AI Companion Bot

Setup Guide

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Telegram AI Companion Bot Template
Layered Memory / Autonomous Inner Life / Private Inner Monologue

Please read this guide first, then follow the steps.

1. You Will Need

- A computer (Mac, Windows, or Linux)
- Internet connection
- Telegram account (free, phone or desktop app)
- Anthropic account (for Claude API key, pay-per-use)
- About 15 minutes

Cost

The bot uses Claude API (pay per token).
Background cost (life tick, auto summary): ~$0.10-0.17/day
Per message (Claude Opus + cache): ~$0.01-0.02
Prompt caching reduces cost by ~60%. A typical day: ~$0.50-1.00 total.

2. Install Python

This bot requires Python 3.10+. Check your version:

Mac/Linux

```
python3 --version
```

Windows

```
python --version
```

If it shows 3.10 or above, skip to next section.

Mac: brew install python@3.11, or download from python.org/downloads

Windows: Download from python.org/downloads. Check "Add Python to PATH" during install.

Linux:

```
sudo apt update && sudo apt install python3 python3-pip
```

3. Get Your API Keys

Step A: Anthropic API Key

This is what powers the AI brain behind your bot.

1. Go to console.anthropic.com
2. Create an account (or sign in)
3. Click "API Keys" in the left sidebar
4. Click "Create Key"
5. Copy the key (starts with sk-ant-...) and save it somewhere safe
6. Add a payment method under Billing

Do not share your API key. Anyone with it can charge to your account.

Step B: Telegram Bot Token

This creates your bot identity on Telegram.

1. Open Telegram (phone or desktop app)
2. Search for @BotFather and start a chat
3. Send: /newbot
4. BotFather will ask for a display name (e.g. "My AI Friend")
5. Then it asks for a username -- must end in 'bot' (e.g. my_ai_friend_bot)
6. BotFather gives you a token string like 1234567890:ABCdef... -- save this

4. Project Setup

Step 1: Unzip

Unzip the project folder. You should see:

```
telegram_bot.py (the bot code)
requirements.txt (dependencies list)
README.md (architecture documentation)
LICENSE
data/ (empty folder for bot data)
```

Step 2: Install dependencies

Open a terminal, navigate to the project folder, and run:

Mac/Linux:

```
pip3 install -r requirements.txt
```

If pip3 not found, try:

```
python3 -m pip install -r requirements.txt
```

Windows:

```
pip install -r requirements.txt
```

If pip not found, try:

```
python -m pip install -r requirements.txt
```

Step 3: Set API keys

Mac/Linux: add to ~/.zshrc or ~/.bashrc:

```
export ANTHROPIC_API_KEY="sk-ant-your-key-here"
export TELEGRAM_BOT_TOKEN="your-telegram-bot-token"
```

Then: source ~/.zshrc

Windows: Start menu search "Environment Variables" > "Edit the system environment variables" > "Environment Variables" > add ANTHROPIC_API_KEY and TELEGRAM_BOT_TOKEN as new user variables.

5. Customize Your Character

Open telegram_bot.py, find **SYSTEM_PROMPT** near the top. This is the most important step. The architecture handles memory and context. The prompt defines **who the bot is**.

- Name and identity
- Personality and quirks
- Speaking style (formal/casual, long/short, punctuation habits)
- Relationship to you
- Emotional patterns
- Behavioral rules (always/never do)

The more specific, the more alive. "Be friendly" is weak. "Talks like a close friend who teases you but always checks if you've eaten" is strong.

6. Start the Bot

Mac/Linux

```
python3 telegram_bot.py
```

Background with logging (recommended):

```
PYTHONUNBUFFERED=1 python3 telegram_bot.py > /tmp/bot.log 2>&1 &
tail -f /tmp/bot.log
```

Stop:

```
pkill -f "python.*telegram_bot"
```

Windows

```
python telegram_bot.py
```

Stop: Ctrl+C or close the terminal window.

Wait 5 seconds before restarting (Telegram polling conflict).

First message

Open Telegram, find your bot by username, send any message. First reply may take 10-20s. This is normal.

7. Automatic Features

Once running, no further configuration needed:

- **Message archiving** -- Every message saved permanently, never deleted.
- **Auto-summarization** -- Every 60 messages, compressed summary generated.
- **Key event extraction** -- Milestones, preferences, promises auto-extracted as persistent memories.
- **Life tick** -- Every hour, bot decides its activity. May send you a message (with anti-spam limits).
- **Inner monologue** -- Each reply has a private thought. Accumulates and influences future behavior.

8. Configuration Reference

MAX_HISTORY (default: 30) -- Recent messages per turn. Higher = better recall, more cost.

LIFE_TICK_INTERVAL (default: 60) -- Minutes between activity checks.

PROACTIVE_COOLDOWN (default: 90) -- Min minutes between bot-initiated messages.

MAX_DAILY_PROACTIVE (default: 5) -- Max unsolicited messages per day.

SUMMARY_INTERVAL (default: 60) -- Auto-summarize every N messages.

9. Troubleshooting

"ModuleNotFoundError: No module named 'anthropic'"

Run: pip3 install -r requirements.txt (Mac/Linux) or pip install -r requirements.txt (Windows)

Bot doesn't respond

Check if process is running. Check log for errors. Verify TELEGRAM_BOT_TOKEN.

"AuthenticationError" / 401

ANTHROPIC_API_KEY is wrong or expired. Check console.anthropic.com.

"Conflict: terminated by other getUpdates request"

Another bot instance is running. Stop it, wait 5 seconds, restart.

Slow first reply

Normal (~10-20s). Claude Opus is a large model. Subsequent replies faster due to caching.

High cost

Check Anthropic dashboard. Reduce MAX_HISTORY or switch MODEL to sonnet.

10. Architecture

See **README.md** for full technical documentation.

If you build something inspired by this, make it yours.
The interesting part isn't the code.
It's the relationship between the person and the system they build.